With access to the Cedar schema, the relevant policies, and the entity relationships, the AI could respond by pointing to a specific `permit` policy and explaining that Kate was a member of the document's reader relationship. This type of explanation helps engineers and policy owners quickly verify whether the system's behavior matches the intended design.

These explanations were never regarded as authoritative. Engineers routinely checked them against the actual policy evaluation trace. When the AI's explanation was vague or surprising, it prompted a closer inspection of the policy. In several instances, this revealed policies that were technically correct but poorly expressed, making them difficult to understand.

17.2.2 Exploring alternative expressions of intent

ACME also used AI to explore various methods of expressing the same authorization intent. Suppose a product owner requested a change such as:

> *"Deny Kate access to this document, but don't affect other customers."*

Instead of immediately editing policies, an engineer would ask the AI how to achieve the desired outcome. The AI might suggest creating a new `forbid` policy targeting that specific principal and resource. When asked for alternatives, it might instead recommend narrowing an existing `permit` policy or adding an `unless` clause to carve out the exception.

Each option was syntactically valid and produced the same result for the immediate request. However, they differed from a design perspective. A new `forbid` policy made the exception explicit but created a narrow exception by increasing the number of policies. A narrower `permit` reduced scope but made the original rule more complex. An `unless` clause kept the general rule intact while clearly documenting the exception.

The AI's role was to quickly surface these alternatives. Choosing among them required human judgment regarding clarity, maintainability, and how authority should be expressed. The AI sped up exploration without determining which policy best aligned with ACME's intent and style.